



GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · VERSION 1.0

THE MOUTH OF SILENCE

A vertical slice of The Chronicles of Demise, Book 1, Chapter 4: "The Scholars of Annea"

GENRE

2D narrative puzzle adventure

PLATFORMS

Windows · web (itch.io)

ENGINE

Unity 6 · C# · URP 2D

LENGTH

30 to 40 minutes

AUTHOR

Umut Eren Demirci

BUILD

0.6.0 · September 2026

- 01 Overview
- 02 Story and characters
- 03 The chapter, area by area
- 04 Kha'shul: the core mechanic
- 05 Astromancy: the star chart
- 06 The Sanctuary's systems
- 07 The crew: movement and dialogue
- 08 Conceptual Bleed

- 09 Controls, UI and onboarding
- 10 Art direction
- 11 Audio and voice
- 12 Saving, settings and platforms
- 13 Technical design
- 14 Process and playtesting
- 15 Scope, credits and roadmap

READING IS POWER

A scholar with no weapon, a language that rewrites the world, and a vault the gods erased from every map.

HIGH CONCEPT

A top-down pixel-art adventure where the only verb that matters is **reading**. Lyssia copies the words of **Kha'shul**, the Ancients' language of definition, into her notebook, and speaks them at glowing places to redefine the world: stone rises, fire stills, mist holds. Every puzzle teaches one rule of a small, real grammar.

PLAYER FANTASY

Being the cleverest person in a dangerous room: the thief, the mercenary and the fake god can't open the door. The scholar can, because she understood it.

AUDIENCE

Players of short narrative puzzle games (*Heaven's Vault*, *Chants of Sennaar*, *Night in the Woods*): people who like language, lore and characters more than reflexes. No combat; failure never costs progress.

WHY A SLICE

A finished, polished chapter proves the core loop (learn, compose, speak, see the world change) and the tone, as a portfolio piece and a pitch for the full game.

DESIGN PILLARS

1 · READING IS POWER

No weapon, no combat. Every obstacle yields to understanding.

2 · ONE RULE AT A TIME

Each puzzle introduces exactly one grammar rule, then tests it in a new context: introduce, practise, combine.

3 · THE CREW TALKS

Companions react to everything; humour carries the lore, and wrong answers get a reaction instead of a fail state.

4 · POWER REWRITES YOU

After the Touch, Conceptual Bleed changes how Lyssia speaks and how the escape plays.

AT A GLANCE

6

areas

10

Kha'shul words

5

grammar rules

343

voiced lines

33

dialogue choices

56

rule tests

A HEIST FOR A BOOK THE GODS ERASED

From the author's manuscript: characters, names and many lines come straight from Chapter 4.

PREMISE

The Tribunal Gods rule the Canvas and teach that nothing existed before them. Lyssia was expelled from the Academy for writing otherwise; the Dean burned her thesis. Now she has hired a crew to reach Annea, a scatter of floating islands scraped off every map, and the Vault of the Ancients inside the **Mouth of Silence**. Somewhere in it lies the **Verses of the Void**.

THE CHAPTER'S QUESTION

What survives the fire? The Black Mirror asks it aloud. The night before, at a campfire, each companion answers it without being asked, and the player's answer (**GHAR-OTH**, "the truth remains") closes the thread. Themes: erasure and memory; definition versus conversation; the cost of knowing.

STRUCTURE

Prologue on the airship; arrival and jungle; the campfire; the Throat; the Mirror; the Sanctuary; the Touch and the escape. It ends as the book's chapter does: the crew leaps from a broken window, and in Lyssia's arms the Verses begin to glow.

THE CREW

	ROLE	WANTS / HIDES
LYSSIA	Scholar, the player. Reads and speaks Kha'shul.	Proof the world is bigger than the Tribunal's cage / that the proof matters more than the cost.
VESPER	Thief and scout. Throws the grapple.	A door that locks from the inside / that she hopes at all.
RYSTAK	Mercenary with the Widow-Maker axe.	One thing that holds still / the debt he still pays on the axe.
CAELUS	Con man posing as a god. Resonance-fork.	Proof the gods are just good engineers / that the paint is for himself.

Written for the ear. Every line is voiced; the four voices were cast by ear from generated samples (section 11). Writing rules and the crew's voices are in [Docs/WRITING.md](#).



The campfire: the one quiet scene, and the setup for the Black Mirror.

SEVEN BEATS, FOUR SCENES

Teaching peaks alternate with rests. Every scene change has a title card or one of the book's Narrator's Notes.

#	AREA	BEATS	TEACHES	TIME
0	The Icarus 34x17 tiles	Crew banter; the star chart (read the sky, plot the course)	Astromancy	3-5 min
1	The Golden Drift 112x21 tiles	Landing; Vesper's grapple across a gap	Movement, talking	3 min
2	The jungle and the camp 112x21 tiles	Carvings; the fallen bridge; the vines; the campfire night	Rule 1 · Declare	8 min
3	The Throat 60x19 tiles	The fire; the mist gap	Rules 2 · 3	6 min
4	The Black Mirror 60x19 tiles	The riddle; the crew's guesses	Rule 4 · Self	4 min
5	The Sanctuary of Orbits 33x34 tiles	The glass floor; the orbits of books	Rule 5 · Coordinates	6 min
6	The Touch and the escape 33x34 tiles	The vision; Sentinels; the Sun-Sphere; the jump	Review under pressure	4 min



The prologue on the Icarus.



The Throat: Lyssia's glow-crystal is the light.

Pacing by design. The camp sits between the jungle and the Throat because Vesper refuses to go in after dark: a motivated rest before the densest stretch of teaching, and the setup for the Mirror.

LEARN, COMPOSE, SPEAK

A constructed language as the puzzle system. Full reference: MouthOfSilence_Khashul_Reference.pdf.

THE LOOP

1. **Find** a carving. Lyssia reads it aloud and copies 1-2 words into her notebook.
2. **Reach** a glowing definition point (a bridge, a fire, a mirror) and press E.
3. **Compose** a sentence from copied words: STATE-ROOT, or STATE-ROOT-ROOT for compounds.
4. **Speak**. A correct definition changes the world; a grammatical near miss does something harmless and gets a reaction; an ungrammatical one gets a one-line lesson. Then try again, freely.

FIVE RULES, ONE PER PUZZLE

RULE	SENTENCE	RESULT
1 · Declare	KEL-DUUN	the bridge stands up
2 · No negation	MUR-ISS	the fire is declared still
3 · Compounds	TOR-VASH-DUUN	mist-stone holds
4 · Self-definition	GHAR-OTH	the Mirror opens
5 · Coordinates	RHEN-SAEL	the orbits turn to Lyssia

VOCABULARY GROWS WITH THE PUZZLES

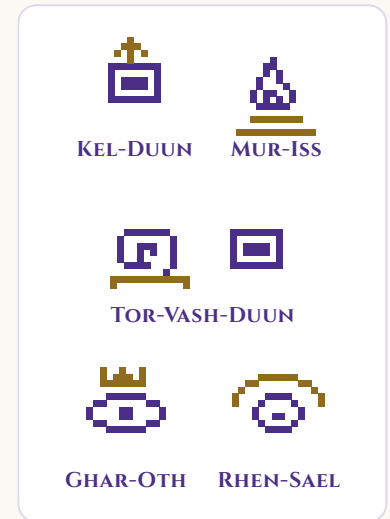
4 words at the bridge, 8 at the mist, 9 at the Mirror, 10 in the Sanctuary. The notebook never shows a word Lyssia hasn't copied, so each puzzle's choice space is small and growing.



The notebook: copied words as cards; the sentence is written as one glyph.

GLYPHS

Roots are shapes, states are strokes; a sentence is written as one glyph.



Failure is content. Each point lists 2-3 designed near misses: **MUR-DUUN** at the bridge silences the stone instead of lifting it ("Great. Now it's quiet and broken.").

READ THE SKY, THEN USE IT

The prologue's puzzle, from the manuscript's first draft: the stars over Annea pulse in a code.



TWO HALVES, ONE SKILL

Read the sky. Three constellations (Serpent, Eagle, Lion) pulse short and long beats; each beat pattern writes itself out beneath the stars. Click a constellation and pick the word with the same beats from Lyssia's key. The message: *hidden · island · knowledge*, and the fog lifts from the hidden island on the chart.

Plot the course. 10 islands, one-way updrafts. Click islands along the winds from the Icarus to the Drift, never through danger, and in as few hops as possible (the Tribunal patrols at dawn). The unique quickest route takes 3 hops.

THE KEY

WORD	BEATS
hidden	• • —
island	— •
knowledge	— — •
danger	• — •
home	• • •
storm	— • •
calm	—

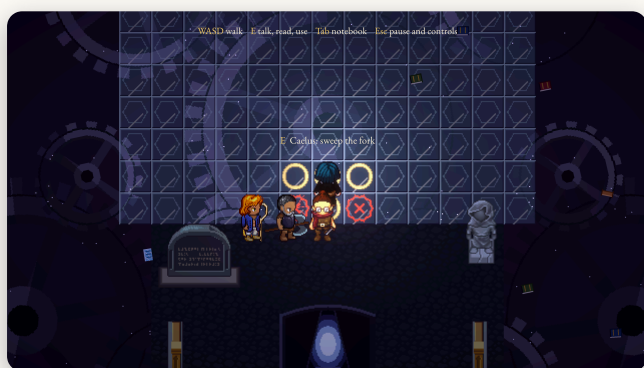
Changed after playtesting. Build 0.4.0's chart was "much harder than the language puzzles". The rules stayed; the information became visible: beats that write out, beats beside every choice, wrong answers that say why, numbered steps, and a mark ("calm") on every island.

GLASS, ORBITS, ESCAPE

Three short systems, each a variation on reading. Rules in Core (*GlassFloor* , *Escape*), tested.

THE GLASS FLOOR

Hexagonal panes over the Gravity Engine. At the glass, Caelus sweeps his fork (E): every pane around Lyssia rings for 7 seconds. **Safe**: a smooth gold ring and a C-major chord. **Trap**: a jagged red ring with a cross and D-minor. Stepping on a trap inverts gravity: the crew floats up and is set back at the start, and the pane stays cracked as a landmark. The safe route winds, with dead-end spurs; on the glass the crew walks in Lyssia's footsteps.



Caelus's fork: safe and trap panes differ in sound, colour and shape.

THE ORBITS

Two rings of books circle the pedestal, each with one gap on the far side. The Rhen carving teaches Rule 5: **RHEN-SAEL** (turns, to the self) swings a ring's gap round to wherever Lyssia stands.



The pedestal inside two orbits of books.

THE ESCAPE

PARAMETER	VALUE
Sentinels	3, waking 5 s apart
Approach speed	$0.055 + 0.01 \times n$ of the distance per second
Stall (Mur-Duun, Tor-Duun)	$3.5 \text{ s} + \text{Expression} \times 0.05$
Knock back (Kel-Duun)	back to the walls, 0.8 s pause
A Sentinel arrives	Rystak's axe: -15 Integrity, 1.5 s recoil
Notebook open	time at 15%
Win	survive 40 s: the Sun-Sphere
Integrity 0	the attempt restarts; no game over

Lyssia can't move (her hand is fused to the book), so the escape is pure Kha'shul under pressure: the first words the player learned, used as reflexes.

COMPANIONS, NOT FOLLOWERS

The crew walks, idles and talks like people. Both came from playtest feedback: "they follow her like sheep".

MOVEMENT

Each companion steers to a personal place beside Lyssia, relative to where she's heading, instead of stepping in her footprints. They react after their own delay, ease in and out of walking, jog to catch up, and keep apart from each other. When she stands still they glance at each other, and the curious ones wander off to look at things. Where the way is blocked, or on the glass floor, they fall back to her footsteps.

	SLOT	REACTION	WALK / JOG	CURIOSITY
VESPER	at her shoulder	0.12 s	3.3 / 5.2	0.5
RYSTAK	guarding behind	0.35 s	3.0 / 4.6	0.15
CAELUS	dawdling at the back	0.55 s	2.9 / 5.0	0.7

Lyssia walks at 3.2 tiles per second; walk cycles play at the speed each character moves.

DIALOGUE

A plain-text script: nodes, lines, choices, conditions on flags and known words, events and Bleed variants. The Game layer only displays what Core's `DialogueRunner` emits.

	COUNT
Nodes	102
Lines	314
Choices	33
Bleed variants	17
LYSSIA	102
VESPER	66
CAELUS	63
RYSTAK	59
NARRATOR	24

BRANCHING WITHOUT BRANCHING PLOT

The plot is linear; *who says what* branches. The camp sets `camp-vesper`, `camp-rystak`, `camp-caelus`; at the Mirror six conditional lines return each companion's answer to them. See *MouthOfSilence_Script_Sample.pdf*.

POWER REWRITES YOU

The slice's twist, and a preview of a system for the full game.

WHAT HAPPENS

When Lyssia lays her bare hand on the Verses, a vision plays (four images from the manuscript and the Weaver's voice: *I only wanted to hold the door shut*). A white shockwave, and the game changes:

- **Dialogue.** 17 of Lyssia's lines have a metaphor variant, written after `||` in the script. "I can't. It's heavy." becomes "It is heavier than the island. My hand has forgotten how to open."
- **Stats.** Integrity (falling) and Expression (rising) appear. In the escape, Expression lengthens every stall; each Sentinel that reaches her costs Integrity.
- **Grammar lessons** turn into metaphor too: "Backwards" becomes "The thing before its law? The stone laughs at me."

WHY

The chapter is about the cost of knowing. Bleed makes that cost audible (Lyssia starts to sound like the language) and mechanical (Integrity), without a fail state.



The Touch: every option ends in the touch.

For the full game. Expression should open alternative solutions (definitions only a bled Lyssia can speak), while Integrity limits them: a real trade-off rather than a longer stall.

KEYBOARD, GAMEPAD, MOUSE

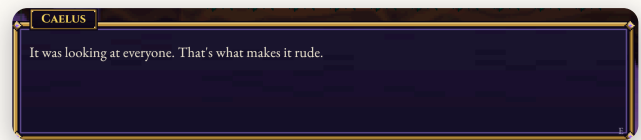
ACTION	KEYBOARD	GAMEPAD
Walk	WASD / arrows	Stick / d-pad
Talk, read, use	E / Space / Enter	A
Notebook	Tab / N	Y
Add a word / remove	arrows + E / Backspace	A / X
Speak	Enter	Y
Pause	Esc	Start

ONBOARDING

- A one-line controls hint after the opening lines, once per game.
- Prompts above interactables name the action ("E Read the carving", "E the fallen bridge").
- Each carving teaches its words aloud, and a companion restates the rule in their own voice.
- The notebook's sentence line reminds: "The definition comes first."
- Grammar mistakes get a one-line reason; nothing is ever lost.

UI STYLE

Generated pixel frames in the game's palette (gold bevel, violet line, corner gems), a leather-bound notebook, a speaker nameplate on the dialogue box, the Cinzel and EB Garamond fonts. Every line is subtitled.



The dialogue box: a nameplate in the speaker's colour.



The notebook: framed word cards in a leather binding.

Fixed from playtesting. A mouse-clicked word card kept UI focus, so Enter spoke *Kel-Duun-Duun*. Cards no longer take focus, and a word can't be added twice.

VIOLET DUSK OVER FLOATING RUINS

LPC pixel art (32 x 32, 640 x 360 at 3x) plus original art drawn by editor scripts.

PALETTE AND MOOD

Violet and gold for Annea (the chapter's violet mist), cold blue-black inside the Mouth, white and lilac for Kha'shul light. 2D lights and post-processing (bloom, vignette) make glyphs, crystals and fire glow.

GENERATED, NOT PAINTED

Scenes are built from text maps: LPC terrain autotiled on a half-offset grid, cliff undersides with hanging roots drawn to each island's shape, seeded scatter of foliage and ruins. Original art is drawn by code:

- the **Icarus**: hull, a patched and netted balloon, deck furniture
- the **Mouth of Silence**: a tilted obsidian face whose mouth is the gateway
- the **Black Mirror**, its cracks and mercury
- the **Sanctuary**: gears, glass, dais, books, window, Sentinels
- UI frames and the Kha'shul glyphs

Changing art is a rebuild, not a repaint, which kept a solo, zero-budget project consistent.



The jungle: LPC tiles, generated cliffs and scatter.



The Icarus: hull, balloon and deck, all generated.

A VOICED CHAPTER ON A ZERO BUDGET

VOICE-OVER

All 343 lines are voiced with the open Kokoro-82M text-to-speech model, rendered offline (no service, no cost). Casting was done by ear from samples, two rounds, per character:

VOICE	
LYSSIA	af_bella
VESPER	af_nicole
RYSTAK	bm_lewis + am_fenrir blend
CAELUS	bm_george
NARRATOR	bm_lewis + bm_fable blend
WEAVER	onyx + fenrir, pitched down, stone echo

- Names the model mispronounced are fixed in IPA ("Lyssia" is Lis-see-a, not Lish-a).
- Lines are spoken phrase by phrase with real pauses at "... " and full stops, for more emotional delivery.
- Clips are keyed by a hash of speaker and text, shared by the render script and the game (tested): editing a line re-renders only that line.

SOUND

Small synthesised sounds, generated at runtime: the fork's C-major and D-minor chords, the Sentinels' clang, rumbles, shattering glass, the Verses' pulse. The distinct chords make the glass floor readable by ear.

MUSIC

The author's own *Tarot Album* (lyrics by the author, tracks generated on a paid plan) is licensed for the credits; area loops are planned for the full game.

Subtitles for everything. Every voiced line is on screen, and the settings have separate volume and voice sliders.



Caelus, voiced by bm_george, at the Black Mirror.

PICK UP WHERE YOU LEFT OFF

CHECKPOINTS

One autosave slot, written when you arrive in an area, after every solved definition (once its reaction has played), at first light at the camp, and when you quit. A save holds the story state (words, flags, Bleed) and the area with a spawn point or Lyssia's position.

Puzzles stay solved through a story flag per point: loading re-applies the point's effect from

`Definitions.txt`, so no puzzle needs its own save code.

EXCEPTIONS

- From the Touch to the jump nothing saves: a reload resumes before the Touch.
- Mid-Sanctuary saves resume at its entrance (the rings and glass aren't stored).
- Finishing the chapter clears the save; the credits return to the title.

SETTINGS

Volume, voice volume, fullscreen; kept between runs.



The title screen: Continue names the checkpoint and its time.

PLATFORMS

	WINDOWS	WEB (ITCH.IO)
Size	159 MB	48 MB (gzip)
Save	save.json (atomic write)	PlayerPrefs, flushed to IndexedDB
Quit	menu, pause Q, window close	hidden; saves when the tab loses focus

Found in testing. The first web build lost every save on reload: Unity's in-memory file system wasn't flushed to the browser's storage. A small JavaScript plugin now syncs after every save.

RULES IN PURE C#, CONTENT IN TEXT

ASSEMBLY	LINES	CONTENTS
Core	1266	Kha'shul parser and definitions, dialogue, story state, star chart, glass floor, escape, saves, voice keys. No UnityEngine.
Game	4587	Movement, crew AI, interaction, dialogue box, notebook, chart screen, effects, scene flow, saves, audio.
Editor	4856	Scene and area builders, art generators, release builds, debug menu.

DATA THE DESIGNER OWNS

Lexicon.txt · Definitions.txt · Dialogue/*.txt · StarChart.txt
 · Areas/*.txt · Decor.txt · Credits.txt

56 EDITMODE TESTS ON THE REAL DATA

- Grammar: every rule and error.
- Every dialogue reference resolves; every solvable point names an effect.
- Star chart: an unambiguous key; the quickest route exists and avoids danger.
- Glass floor: a safe route exists and is longer than the direct one.
- Escape: stalls, knocks, Expression, losing, winning.
- Saves: JSON round trip, snapshots, broken saves. Voice keys match Python.

BUILT WITH AN AI CODING ASSISTANT

The game was built in Unity with Claude as the programming partner. I owned the design (story, language, puzzles, tuning, writing, casting) and play-tested each of six phases; Claude wrote the code to that design, drove the editor through an automation bridge, and verified features with screenshots and tests.

TOOLING

- Scenes regenerate from data ([Build > All Scenes](#)); nothing is hand-edited.
- A debug menu jumps to every puzzle and can speak any sentence.
- Release builds for Windows and WebGL; published to itch.io with butler.
- These documents are generated from the same data.

More: *MouthOfSilence_Flowcharts.pdf* (8 system diagrams), [Docs/ARCHITECTURE.md](#).

SIX PHASES, ONE OUTSIDE PLAYTEST

PHASE	GOAL	RESULT
1 · Plan	Scope a finishable slice on a laptop, zero budget	Design, Kha'shul grammar, architecture, asset licences
2 · Core	The language and dialogue as tested rules	Parser, definitions, dialogue runner, notebook, test room
3 · Areas 1-3	The Icarus, Annea, the Throat	Star chart, grapple, bridge, fire, mist; generated environments
4 · Areas 4-6	The Mirror to the jump	Mirror, glass floor, orbits, the Touch, escape, credits
+ Feel pass	Author feedback	Balloon airship, crew AI, campfire, voice-over, dialogue rewrite
5 · Save	Checkpoints and a title	Autosave, title screen, settings
6 · Ship	Builds and documents	Windows and web on itch.io, store page, these PDFs

WHAT THE PLAYTEST CHANGED

"The star chart is too obscure." The rules stayed; the information became visible (section 05).

"Kel-Duun registers two Duuns." A UI focus bug; fixed at the root, and repeated words are now refused.

"Some islands have no icons." Every island now has a mark; unmarked ones became "calm".

"The crew follows like sheep." Steering with personalities (section 07).

"The UI looks basic." Generated pixel frames, nameplates, a leather notebook.

"The ship looks like a raft." A balloon airship with a lived-in deck.

Method. Each phase ended with a playable build, a summary and a test script; nothing moved on without a go-ahead. Bugs found by the builder were fixed before handing over; bugs found by players changed the design.

IN, OUT, AND NEXT

IN THE SLICE

- 6 areas, 30-40 minutes, fully voiced with subtitles
- Kha'shul: 10 words, 5 rules, 6 definition puzzles
- Astromancy, the glass floor, the orbits, the escape
- Branching dialogue, Conceptual Bleed, the campfire
- Autosave, settings; keyboard, gamepad, mouse; Windows and web

OUT, ON PURPOSE

- Combat and health for Lyssia
- Inventory beyond the notebook
- Branching plot
- Other realities of the Canvas

CREDITS

Story, design, Kha'shul and writing: Umut Eren Demirci.
 Art: Liberated Pixel Cup artists (CC-BY-SA 3.0 / GPL 3.0; the full list is in-game and in [CREDITS.md](#)). Voices: Kokoro TTS (Apache 2.0). Fonts: Cinzel, EB Garamond (OFL).
 Music: *The Tarot Album* by Umut Eren Demirci.

ROADMAP

- **Hint ladder.** A companion's nudge after a minute, then the notebook highlights a word.
- **Bleed as choice.** Expression opens alternative definitions; Integrity limits them.
- **Chapter 5.** Test whether Kha'shul scales past 10 words without becoming a vocabulary test: more rules, not more words.
- **Music.** Area loops and a credits track from the Tarot Album.
- **Accessibility.** Text size, reduced motion, remappable keys.

PLAY IT

ueren.itch.io/the-mouth-of-silence

In the browser, or download for Windows.